

URBAN HORIZON Bhopal skyline by the Upper Lake

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BEING BRUTALIST TOWARDS BHOPAL

Greedy realtors, politicos with personal stakes, greasy babus team up to deface a beautiful, planned city

By **Rahul Noronha**

HOW DOES A government ruin one of India's most scenic and planned state capitals? Simply by looking the other way when building norms are trashed. Bhopal—known for its undulating hills, wide roads and tree-lined avenues—has been lately gasping for breath. A cabal of greedy businessmen and politicians, supported by an allegedly corrupt bureaucracy, has allowed one of the most beautiful parts of the city to be ravaged through rampant violations of the master plan.

The effect: untamed commercialisation of residential areas, and its usual bequest of clogged roads and sound and air pollution. It's gotten so foul that the high court has roundly upbraided the authorities and laid down red lines. On July 29, hearing a PIL filed by Arera Colony resident Purnendu Shukla and environmentalist Subhash Pandey, a bench of Chief Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva and Justice Vinay Saraf issued notices to the state government, municipal corporation and power utility. In the interim, it decreed a halt to all violative action.

The PIL expresses a universal dismay, even if the litigants have cited only Arera Colony, in South Bhopal, where the problem is acute. The colony was developed in 1968 with subsidised allotments to individuals with the specific purpose of constructing residential units. The Floor Area Ratio (FAR), fixed on the lower side then, continues at 0.75—meaning construction is allowed only on 75 per cent of plot area.

Takeaways

- **The HC issues notice to MP government et al on rampant breach of Bhopal master plan**
- **A rash of commercial realty at Arera Colony said to have become a sink for black money**

ALL OVER THE SHOP

Subsequent master plans consistently earmarked Arera for residential land use, eschewing commercial usage. Reason: its infrastructure could only support limited traffic and parking. The Bhopal Development Plan 1995-2005, in force now, adheres to that. So did the last draft of the proposed new master plan, since cancelled by the Mohan Yadav government, and a 2008 draft, also later cancelled. Only a draft floated in 2020 by the then Kamal Nath government, again later cancelled, had proposed mixed land use for it.

Even so, a mercantile beehive sprung up: restaurants, showrooms, banks et al. The Bhopal Municipal Corporation didn't miss the action: it merrily collects commercial rent from these illegal structures. In a similar bestowal of indulgence, the MP Central Region Power Distribution Company gave connections at commercial rates—milking the illegality. With de facto legitimacy, safety in numbers and the technical shield of a delayed master plan, breach of law nearly became law. Once, two commercial structures that got sealed were reopened after judicial relief.

The list of violators reads like a who's who of politics. Ex-CM/Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan's son's dairy has its business office at Arera. Deputy LoP and Congress MLA Hemant Katare's family owns buildings that house a gym, two restaurants and a bank. A Bhopal-based minister's brother has a structure coming up. I-T sources speak of a rash of benami investments, since real estate is still the biggest sink for black money: numerous officials, doctors and suchlike are said to be drawing hefty rental incomes.

Over a fortnight since the halt order, work continues on many commercial structures. Top government sources let on that the new draft of the Bhopal Development Plan 2047 is ready and would be released soon—and that in all likelihood, Arera Colony will be declared a mixed land use area. ■